

WANTING TO BE RICH

I WAS TOLD THAT BEFORE YOU CAN ENRICH YOURSELF, YOU HAVE to *want* to get richer. Here I have a confession to make. In the past, I've flirted with the dangerous notion that money isn't everything. This usually occurred to me after I'd made a bad investment. On those sad occasions, I'd announce that rich people were "miserable," "living empty lives," or "too greedy for their own good," or I'd repeat such mottos as "It's better to be happy than greedy," "Any dummy can make a fortune," and "At least we have our health." Prosperous couples featured on the program "Lifestyles of the Rich and Famous" never looked gloomier nor more forlorn than after I'd suffered some financial setback.

Now that I'm getting all this out in the open, I might as well make a clean breast of it. Beyond the idea that money isn't everything, I also believed that the dumb investor was morally superior to the smart one. If money makes people hate their children and lead miserable lives, then any of the numerous losses I've described could only have brought me closer to spiritual perfection and ultimate enlightenment. I felt especially virtuous as Sykes Data-tronics was plunging from \$11 toward zero, and nearly saintlike as Anacomp declined from \$20 to \$2.

I can trace this primitive attitude back to my college days, when many among us were convinced we never wanted to get richer. A majority of college students in the mid- to late-1960s was determined to avoid financial success. In those days, an A in pre-Colombian politics was more highly prized than an A in accounting fundamentals. We never bothered to learn how to account for anything, unless it was for the differences in pre-Socratic creation myths. Many of us knew more about the Norman Conquest than